

Søren Kierkegaard, writing under the pseudonym of Johannes De Silentio, tells the story of Abraham and his son Issac in the *Prelude* of his book, *Fear and Trembling*. He lists four accounts really; each one with a different focus, but all of them very close in nature. It seems then that this particular story, from *The Book of Genesis*, has certain philosophical dilemmas that Kierkegaard, or more correctly, Johannes, finds interesting and wishes to explore (exploit). He highlights two philosophical concepts, or movements: the knight of infinite resignation, and the knight of faith. These two movements will first be defined; then their differences will be addressed; and finally, it will be shown how Abraham, the *hero* of the story, becomes a knight of first *resignation*, and then of *faith*.

So what is a knight of infinite resignation? And what sigil do they wear on their chest? Well, it isn't like that, exactly. In simple terms, the knight of infinite resignation, well, resigns from everything in life that gives to them pleasure. When the knight is faced with desires, they will be resigned to the fact of reality – they understand that what they want in this life is not going to be given to them, and even though it causes them pain, (eventually) they accept things for what they are. For Johannes, one needs to be a knight of infinite resignation before they can become a knight of faith. An example of this would be someone like a priest or a monk – an ascetic. He states, “With infinite regression he has drained the cup of life’s profound sadness, he knows the bliss of the infinite, he senses the pain of renouncing everything.” (18)

Now let us attempt to understand the concept of the knight of faith. Here, the knight believes wholly in both himself and in God – thee ol’ *with God all things are possible*. The knight moves past resignation and into the realm of receiving. For only then will faith be rewarded. Even when faced with logical contradictions, the knight stays committed to their faith. This is what Kierkegaard refers to as *the absurd*. “He resigned everything infinitely, and then he

grasped everything again by virtue of the absurd” (18) If the knight of faith knows that they cannot achieve something, they give up that which they hold dear, yet at the same time embrace the absurd, the illogical, the irrational. This is what Kierkegaard calls the *Double Movement*. The knight believes that what they long for can still be theirs as long as they keep the faith, for the boat of faith doesn’t sink in the ocean of impossibility.

Comparing the two movements, it seems that the following is true: the knight of infinite resignation seems to be more in the pursuit of knowledge, seeking what the divine (or infinite) is exactly. The knight of faith on the other hand, has faith overflowing, which leaves them not to question much, instead they follow what the divine commands. It’s hard for this knight to communicate their mission with others. “I have not found any reliable example of the knight of faith, though I would not therefore deny that every second [person] may be such an example.” (16)

Keeping in mind that Kierkegaard believes that one needs resignation in order to have faith, let us now see which type of knight, if any, Abraham turns out to be. From the story we see that Abraham is asked by God to sacrifice his most beloved son, Issac. From this, Abraham becomes a knight of infinite resignation. He then goes to where he should, with Issac, and just as he is about to put a blade to his son’s throat, God voices over to a ram that is to be sacrificed instead. This part of the story is where Abraham goes from being a knight of infinite resignation to a knight of faith. He resigned from everything but Issac, yet just as he was about to give up that which he loved most, he gained it all back, and arguably with more appreciation than before. Abraham experienced the *Double Movement* as he was about to strike Issac – Abraham believed that even though he was about to kill his son, that because he held strong to his faith, everything would be okay in the end. Fortunately, he was correct.

One cannot deny the intrigue that sprouts from reading about the two the knights that Kierkegaard posited. It should be an easy task to see moving forward, which of our favorite characters (from books or television) have the properties of a knight of infinite resignation, and which ones seem to uphold what it means to be a knight of faith. With all that, I shall ask this: what seems harder, resigning from everything in life that is pleasurable in hopes of becoming closer to the divine, or keeping the faith in a time when more than prayers seem necessary?